

MEMORANDUM OF UNDERSTANDING

KNOW ALL MEN BY THESE PRESENTS:

"This Memorandum of Understanding ("MOU") is made and entered into this 6th day of February 2026, in Quezon City, Philippines, by and between:

The **DEPARTMENT OF SOCIAL WELFARE AND DEVELOPMENT**, a government agency duly organized and existing under the existing laws of the Republic of the Philippines, with principal office address at DSWD Central Office, IBP Road, Batasan Pambansa Complex, Constitution Hills, Quezon City, herein represented by its Secretary, **Honorable REXLON T. GATCHALIAN**, hereinafter referred to as "**DSWD**",

And

The **COMMISSION ON HIGHER EDUCATION (CHED)**, a national government agency duly organized and existing under the laws of the Republic of the Philippines with principal office at C.P Garcia Avenue, Quezon City, represented herein by its Chairperson, **Honorable SHIRLEY C. AGRUPIS**, hereinafter referred to as "**CHED**".

DSWD and CHED, shall individually be referred to herein as a "Party" and collectively as the "Parties".

WITNESSETH, that

WHEREAS, the DSWD, through the DSWD Academy, is institutionalizing a competency-based learning, certification, and accreditation system anchored on the HEARTWORK Framework to strengthen ethical practice, service quality, and professional competence of the social welfare and development (SWD) workforce;

WHEREAS, the CHED is mandated to promote outcomes-based education (OBE), quality assurance, and lifelong learning pathways that are responsive to national development priorities and workforce needs;

WHEREAS, both Parties recognize the importance of strengthening the continuum between higher education, professional practice, continuing education, and lifelong learning, particularly in the social welfare and social protection sectors;

WHEREAS, both Parties affirm the role of the Philippine Qualifications Framework (PQF) in ensuring the comparability, portability, and recognition of learning outcomes across education and training systems;

WHEREAS, the Parties recognize the Expanded Tertiary Education Equivalency and Accreditation Program (ETEEAP) as a strategic mechanism for academic recognition of learning, competencies, and relevant work experience acquired outside of a traditional classroom setting that has been formally evaluated and officially recognized as equivalent to academic credit, particularly for social welfare and development personnel.

WHEREAS, the Parties commit to the CHED-DSWD ASCEND (Accelerated Social Work Credentialing and Equivalency for National Development) Program as a quality-assured credentialing and equivalency pathway enabling Social Work degree completion or equivalency through ETEEAP, Recognition of Prior

Learning (RPL), and stackable micro-credentials, in partnership with deputized higher education institutions (HEIs);

WHEREAS, DSWD is the primary government agency mandated to develop, administer, and implement comprehensive social welfare and protection programs and poverty-reduction solutions designed to uplift the living conditions and empower the poor, vulnerable, and disadvantaged children, youth, women, older persons, persons with disabilities, families or persons in crisis or at risk, and communities needing assistance;

NOW, THEREFORE, for and in consideration of the foregoing premises, the Parties hereby commit as follows:

ARTICLE I PURPOSE

This Memorandum of Understanding aims to establish a formal framework of cooperation between DSWD and CHED to strengthen the alignment of higher education, competency-based training, certification, and continuing professional development in the social welfare and development sector, including the utilization of the Expanded Tertiary Education Equivalency and Accreditation Program (ETEEAP) as a strategic pathway for academic recognition of professional practice.

Specifically, this MOU seeks to:

1. Harmonize higher education programs with competency-based learning and certification pathways consistent with OBE and PQF, in social welfare-related degree and non-degree programs; and
2. Support evidence-based policy, academic planning, and workforce development through regular data sharing, collaborative research and evaluation, and the use of labor market and workforce information to guide program design, implementation, and continuous improvement; and
3. Implement the CHED–DSWD ASCEND Program to establish and scale a quality-assured, CHED-led credentialing and equivalency pathway for qualified SWD practitioners, including: (i) expansion of deputized HEIs and access strategies; (ii) institutionalization of a joint RPL framework that recognizes verified work experience, competency evidence, and relevant DSWD Academy learning records; (iii) development of outcomes-based bridging requirements that are anchored on social work competency expectations; (iv) operationalization of stackable micro-credentials as structured learning interventions that address identified gaps and support degree progression, workforce capability, and continuing professional development; and (v) joint quality assurance, monitoring, and continuous improvement mechanisms.

ARTICLE II AREAS OF COOPERATION

The Parties shall cooperate to strengthen the use, coherence, and effectiveness of alternative and flexible learning and academic recognition pathways—particularly the Expanded Tertiary Education Equivalency and Accreditation Program (ETEEAP)—to support the development and professionalization of the social welfare and development workforce, subject to applicable laws and regulations.

1. ETEEAP and Alternative Academic Recognition Pathways

The Parties shall support the use of ETEEAP as a strategic pathway for academic recognition of prior learning, competencies, and professional experience of social welfare and development personnel, including those engaged in frontline, community-based, and institutional social services. Other flexible and alternative learning pathways may likewise be recognized and aligned, as appropriate, to complement ETEEAP and expand access to higher education opportunities consistent with outcomes-based education and the Philippine Qualifications Framework.

2. Support for Progression toward Social Work Professional Qualifications

The Parties shall collaborate in promoting pathways that enable qualified social welfare and development personnel to progress toward recognized academic qualifications in social work and related fields. In this regard, DSWD, through the DSWD Academy, shall provide relevant competency frameworks, professional practice inputs, and sectoral learning references to support the recognition of prior learning and experience, while CHED shall provide policy guidance and assistance to ensure that such pathways are aligned with higher education standards, quality assurance systems, and applicable professional and academic requirements.

3. Alignment, Quality, and Integrity of Recognition Pathways

The Parties shall promote the coherence, quality, and integrity of ETEEAP and related recognition pathways by supporting alignment with PQF level descriptors, consistency with CHED policies and standards, and the credibility of academic recognition mechanisms, while respecting the distinct mandates of each Party.

4. Evidence, Policy Support, and Continuous Improvement

The Parties shall encourage the use of data, studies, and shared evidence to inform policy direction, academic planning, and workforce strategies related to ETEEAP and other recognition pathways, including their contribution to strengthening the supply, quality, and development of social work and social welfare professionals.

5. CHED-DSWD ASCEND Program Design and Delivery Model

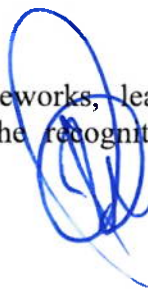
The Parties shall implement ASCEND as a national, quality-assured credentialing and equivalency pathway for qualified SWD practitioners. The Program shall be anchored on existing mechanisms such as the ETEEAP, RPL, and stackable micro-credentials, and may be delivered through deputized Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) and/or consortium-based models, as may be appropriate.

The detailed design, components, governance-structure, timeline, and monitoring and evaluation framework of ASCEND are set forth in Annex "A" (ASCEND Program Design Summary), which shall form an integral part of this MOU."

ARTICLE III ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

A. DSWD – DSWD Academy

1. Provide sector-specific competency frameworks, learning references, and professional practice inputs to support the recognition of prior learning,

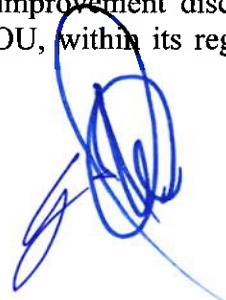


competencies, and experience of social welfare and development personnel, including for ETEEAP, RPL, and related pathways under ASCEND;

2. Share available and relevant workforce information, profiles, and sectoral insights, limited to the purpose of this MOU, subject to applicable laws and regulations, to inform higher education planning, policy development, and workforce alignment;
3. Recognize and, where appropriate, provide DSWD Academy learning records and other verifiable competency evidence as inputs to RPL and assessment decisions, subject to the assessment rules of deputized HEIs and applicable CHED policies;
4. Lead the mobilization, orientation, and coordination of qualified candidates through DSWD Central and Field Offices, consistent with the ASCEND implementation plans and subject to availability of resources;
5. Serve as a technical resource in the alignment of learning outcomes, competency references, and professional practice standards relevant to social welfare and development free of charge, unless expressly provided in a separate MOA and subject to the availability of funds and applicable government accounting, auditing, and budgeting laws; and
6. Support initiatives under this MOU, which may include technical, advisory, coordination, and limited logistical support in a manner consistent with its mandate, subject to the availability of resources and applicable government laws.

B. Commission on Higher Education (CHED)

1. Provide policy guidance, technical assistance, and regulatory support to ensure that ETEEAP and other academic recognition pathways relevant to this MOU are aligned with higher education quality assurance systems, outcomes-based education, and applicable Policies, Standards, and Guidelines (PSGs);
2. Facilitate coordination and linkages with higher education institutions (HEIs), as appropriate, to support the implementation of ETEEAP and other flexible pathways relevant to the social welfare and development sector, including deputization expansion strategies under ASCEND;
3. Promote consistency of aligned pathways with the Philippine Qualifications Framework (PQF) level descriptors and applicable academic requirements;
4. Support the development and standardization of assessment instruments, scoring rubrics, and assessor qualification standards for the ASCEND program; and lead the calibration of academic evaluators to ensure consistent application of RPL policies across all participating HEIs with CHED's mandate and policies; and
5. Participate in monitoring, review, and continuous improvement discussions related to initiatives undertaken pursuant to this MOU, within its regulatory and oversight role.



ARTICLE IV IMPLEMENTATION ARRANGEMENTS

1. The Parties may establish a CHED–DSWD Steering Committee and a Joint Technical Working Group (TWG), or designate focal units or representatives, to serve as a coordination and consultative mechanism for initiatives arising from this MOU, including ASCEND;
2. The Steering Committee and/or TWG, or designated representatives, may, as necessary, identify priority areas of cooperation, agree on general directions or work plans, and periodically review progress, subject to the availability of resources and applicable approvals of each Party;
3. Implementation of specific activities, projects, or programs under this MOU shall be subject to separate agreements, project documents, or issuances, as may be required by applicable laws, rules, and regulations; and
4. All coordination, information sharing, and related activities shall comply with applicable data privacy, audit, accountability, and government regulatory requirements; and
5. To implement the cooperation set forth in this MOU, the Parties agree to execute a Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) that will further describe the purpose, specific details on the parties' mutual covenants, rights, and obligations, and other terms and conditions that shall legally bind the Parties. Parties are not precluded from adding terms of reference and similar guidelines to operationalize the agreements in the MOA to be executed.

ARTICLE V RESOURCES

The Parties shall bear their own cost in the performance of its responsibilities under this MOU, and any expense that the Party may incur relative to the Program shall be subject to applicable laws, rules, and regulations.

ARTICLE VI RELATIONSHIP TO THE PARTIES

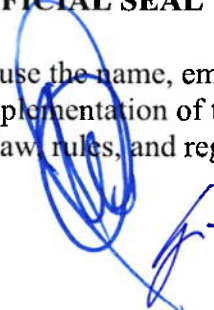
Nothing in this MOU shall be construed to establish a joint venture, agency, or partnership between the Parties, nor does it create a separate legal entity that binds the Parties. Neither Party has the authority nor right to assume, create, or undertake any obligations of any kind whatsoever, expressed or implied, for or on behalf of, or in the name of the other.

ARTICLE VII REPRESENTATION AND WARRANTY

Each Party warrants and represents to the other Party that he/she has the full power and authority to enter into this MOU and to bind the organization so represented.

ARTICLE VIII USE OF NAME, EMBLEM, OR OFFICIAL SEAL

Each Party shall not in any manner whatsoever use the name, emblem, or official seal of DSWD nor the CHED in connection with the implementation of this MOU unless otherwise agreed by the Parties as sanctioned under the law, rules, and regulations.



ARTICLE IX CONFIDENTIALITY AND INFORMATION SHARING

All business and technical data, information, software, and related documentation, in whatever form provided, recorded, or unrecorded (hereinafter collectively referred to as "information") which either Party may furnish or has furnished the other Party are subject to the following:

- A. Shall be used solely for the purpose for which it was furnished;
- B. Shall be treated in strict and absolute confidentiality, and neither Party cannot, without the written consent of the other Party, disclose the information to a third party;
- C. Shall not be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, except as necessary for its authorized use;
- D. Shall be returned (if in tangible form) together with all copies thereof when demanded by the other Party or when no longer needed; and
- E. All electronic information obtained shall be permanently deleted in all of the devices where such information was obtained.

Neither Party shall, without prior written consent of the other Party/ies, disclose or use for its own purposes the confidential information of the other Party/ies acquired during or after the term of this MOU.

Each Party shall take all reasonable precautions to protect the confidential information directly disclosed to it by the other Parties, using at least the same standard of care as it uses to maintain the confidentiality of its own confidential information.

Should there be personal information and/or sensitive information shared between the Parties, a Data Sharing Agreement shall be entered in compliance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012 to ensure the mandatory compliance in line with DSWD practices to support the execution of this MOU.

Therefore, the Parties hereby understood that the terms of this MOU, the Content, the Information, and personal information shall be kept confidential at all times, even after the termination of this MOU.

ARTICLE X EFFECTIVITY AND DURATION

This MOU shall take effect upon signing by both Parties and shall remain valid for a period of five (5) years, subject to renewal, provided mutually agreed upon by the Parties in writing.

This MOU is founded on the good faith and mutual good will of the Parties, who share a common purpose in bringing better services to the key stakeholders.

This MOU shall be jointly reviewed annually by the Parties to ensure it is fulfilling its purpose and to mutually agree on any necessary revision.

ARTICLE XI SEPARABILITY AND TERMINATION

In the event that a Party finds that the objectives or purposes are no longer feasible to attain on account of the other Party's act or omission, or due to acts of God and/or fortuitous events, or for other just and valid causes, the MOU may be terminated

by giving the other Party a written notice of at least thirty (30) calendar days prior to the intended date of termination.

**ARTICLE XII
GENERAL PROVISIONS**

This MOU does not create any binding financial obligation unless covered by a valid separate agreement or approved project document.

IN WITNESS WHEREOF, The Parties have hereunto affixed their signatures on the date and place first written above.

**DEPARTMENT OF SOCIAL
WELFARE AND DEVELOPMENT**

Hon. REXLON T. GATCHALIAN
DSWD Secretary

**COMMISSION ON HIGHER
EDUCATION**

Hon. SHIRLEY C. AGRUPIS
CHED Chairperson

Signed in the presence of:


DENISE FB BERNOS BRAGAS
Undersecretary


DR. MYRNA Q. MALLARI
Commissioner

ANNEX “A”

ASCEND PROGRAM DESIGN SUMMARY

This Annex summarizes the ASCEND (Accelerated Social Work Credentialing and Equivalency for National Development) Program Design referenced in this MOU.

A. Program Objective

ASCEND establishes and scales a quality-assured, CHED-led credentialing and equivalency pathway for qualified social welfare and development practitioners, enabling Social Work degree completion or equivalency through ETEEAP, Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL), and stackable micro-credentials, in partnership with DSWD and deputized HEIs.

B. Specific Objectives

1. Expand access nationwide by increasing the number and geographic spread of deputized HEIs authorized to implement ETEEAP for Social Work, including consortium-based delivery models where appropriate.
2. Institutionalize a joint RPL framework that recognizes verified work experience, competency evidence, and DSWD Academy learning records as valid inputs to assessment and bridging decisions.
3. Operationalize stackable micro-credentials as structured learning interventions that address identified gaps and support degree progression, workforce capability, and continuing professional development.
4. Develop and roll out bridging requirements that are outcomes-based and anchored on social work competency expectations, ensuring completeness without redundancy for experienced practitioners.
5. Strengthen quality assurance through common tools, assessment protocols, and a joint oversight mechanism to ensure consistent standards across participating HEIs.
6. Generate measurable workforce and service outcomes, including improved progression pathways, strengthened retention and leadership pipelines, and enhanced service delivery competence in priority areas.

C. Program Components and Delivery Model

1. Deputization Expansion and Access Strategy

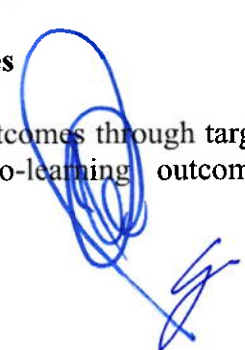
Expand the number and regional distribution of deputized HEIs offering ETEEAP for Social Work; undertake readiness screening, technical assistance for deputization, and assessor capacity-building and calibration.

2. RPL Integration and Evidence Crediting

Institutionalize credible RPL through portfolio standards, verification rules, and crediting logic; develop standardized portfolio templates and evidence checklists; and recognize verifiable DSWD Academy learning records as structured evidence, subject to CHED/HEI assessment rules.

3. Bridging Curriculum and Gap-Filling Modules

Ensure candidates meet Social Work degree outcomes through targeted bridging without redundancy, including competency-to-learning outcomes mapping,



development of modular bridging curricula, capstone/practicum equivalency parameters, and harmonized assessment rubrics suited for working professionals.

4. Stackable Micro-credentials

Design micro-credentials with clear learning outcomes, assessment methods, and stackability pathways aligned to Social Work outcomes; implement quality checks and a registry/traceability mechanism to support authentication and portability.

D. Governance and Quality Assurance

ASCEND governance and quality assurance shall be operationalized through the following mechanisms, as agreed by the Parties and participating HEIs:

1. CHED–DSWD Steering Committee: strategic direction, policy decisions, and inter-agency issue resolution.
2. Joint Technical Working Group (TWG): tool development, assessor standards, monitoring oversight, and quality assurance audits.
3. Deputized HEI Consortium: harmonized implementation, peer calibration, and workload balancing.
4. Regional Nodes (CHEDROs and DSWD Field Offices): candidate mobilization support, scheduling, and local monitoring.

Quality assurance safeguards include common rubrics and portfolio standards, assessor qualification and calibration, verification and audit protocols, documented crediting decisions with an appeals mechanism, and registry/traceability of credentials, consistent with applicable laws and policies.

E. Timeline and Phasing

ASCEND operates as a single national implementation with parallel workstreams that begin immediately upon partnership activation. Indicative milestones include: MOU signing (January 2026) and MOA launch signing (March 2026 during the Higher Education Summit / Social Work Month), subject to mutual agreement and applicable approvals.

F. Monitoring and Evaluation

Monitoring and evaluation shall cover core results areas on (i) access and coverage, (ii) quality and process integrity, (iii) completion and outcomes, and (iv) service and institutional outcomes. Reporting cadence may include monthly operational dashboards (TWG), quarterly steering updates (Steering Committee), and an annual performance report for institutionalization.

Four handwritten signatures in blue ink are located at the bottom of the page. From left to right, there is a signature that appears to be 'Mun', a large circular signature, a signature that looks like 'G', and a signature that looks like 'Fah'.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

REPUBLIC OF THE PHILIPPINES)
QUEZON CITY, M.M.) S.S.

BEFORE ME, a Notary Public for and in QUEZON CITY, M.M. this ___ day of
MAR 04 2026 2026 personally appeared:

Name	Valid ID	Issued at/on
Secretary Rexlon T. Gatchalian	DSWD ID No. 23-0012	Quezon City / 11 Aug 2024

He is known to me to be the same person who executed the foregoing Memorandum of Understanding, consisting of nine (9) pages, including this page on which this acknowledgment is written and signed on each and every page thereof by him and his witness, and he acknowledged to me that the same is his free and voluntary act and deed as well as the Party he represents.

Doc. No. W ;
Page No. 7 ;
Book No. F ;
Series of 2026.

ATTY. FELIZARDO M. IBARRA
Notary Public for Quezon City Until Dec. 31, 2026
Roll No. 80835
PTR No. 8353947, 1/6/26 QC
IBP No. 331161, December 19, 2023
MCLE Comp. No. VII-0000973/ until April 14, 2026
ADM Matter No. NP. 088 / (2025-2026)

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

REPUBLIC OF THE PHILIPPINES)
QUEZON CITY, M.M.) S.S.

BEFORE ME, a Notary Public for and in QUEZON CITY, M.M. this day of
MAR 04 2026, 2026 personally appeared:

Name	Valid ID	Issued at/on
Hon. Shirley C. Agrupis	CHED 10 No. CD - 0582	Quezon City / 30 June 2025

He is known to me to be the same person who executed the foregoing Memorandum of Understanding, consisting of nine (9) pages, including this page on which this acknowledgment is written and signed on each and every page thereof by him and his witness, and he acknowledged to me that the same is his free and voluntary act and deed as well as the Party he represents.

Doc. No. 14 ;
Page No. 7 ;
Book No. II ;
Series of 2026.

ATTY. FELIZARDO M. IBARRA
Notary Public for Quezon City Until Dec. 31, 2026
Roll No. 80835
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IBP No. 331161, December 19, 2023
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